

PREMISE DELTA v0.3 · THE TRUSTING FORGERY · 2026-09-08

Third delta against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 with amendments v1.5 (the locker), v1.6 (the tin), v1.7 (the same night) and v1.8 (terminology). v0.1 (the trust version) and v0.2 (the comfort blanket) were each attacked by two adversaries and rejected; their files and dispositions stand beside this one. v0.3 was built differently: seven load-bearing questions were walked one at a time with Stephen on 2026-09-08, each with the strongest objection stated and an in-world answer attached, and each was accepted before the next was asked. This document is those seven rulings assembled into one premise, plus the sweep of every new fact. Premise v8.1 remains in force until this delta has survived two adversaries and Stephen rules.

1. The device, before and after

Before (v8.1, ruled). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter: I think one of you is planning to kill me, I don't know which. The locker letter, forged by Brad: I know. Chapter 7's turn: dead women don't get surer.

After (v0.3). A woman who trusted four people completely asked them, from behind a padlocked door, to find out who had been getting into her house. She said it was none of them. Three weeks later the four were sure it was one of them. Violet never accuses anyone, alive or dead. The accusation is built at Ruby's kitchen table by the four themselves, out of a list of true things, and the list was written by the one of them who killed her. Brad does not forge her fear. He forges her trust, keeps her voice, keeps her instruction to investigate, and salts it so that four honest people, doing exactly what she asked, arrive at Liam. The room convicts a man she cleared, against her stated word, and never notices that it has.

Everything downstream of the forgery holds as ruled: the room works the letter, it lands on Liam, Margo holds her silence, Brad vanishes off Kestrel Head, Margo dies there five months later, the survivors accuse each other to the police, the police look properly and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. Violet, under this premise

She is forty-four, the best judge of a hand on the coast, and she writes everything down. This autumn two things happen inside her own house. Her tobacco, two a day rolled from the tin under the stairs among the paints and the garden concentrates, comes up stained through the paper, and the lid is loose, and the capped bottle on the shelf above has been moved six inches or has not. And a gilded alphabet panel comes down out of her workshop roof with a ceiling board, in her own alphabet, better than she has ever done it, signed with a mark that is not a name. She carries the panel round the trade asking whose hand it is: the café, the cinema, two other signwriters. Two of them say yours, in a very good year. She does not show it to the four, and the reason is hers and not the plot's: to strangers in the trade it is a professional question; to her pupil of seven years it is a confession that she cannot account for a piece of her own work and it is better than his teacher's. She will not hand Brad that. The other three are not lettering people and a signwriter carrying a panel is not news to them. (Nobody in town knows Brad can gild; his public work is boat names and pub signs.)

She believes someone with her spare key has been in her house. She also believes, on alternate days, that she is imagining it. She does not suspect any of the four for a second; they are the people she would call first, and the reason she cannot call them is not fear of them but that she has nothing to show them except a loose lid and a panel she may have made herself, and she would rather be laughed at after she is gone than watched while she is here. So she does what she does with everything: writes it down, plainly, and puts it where it cannot be got at. She changes the padlock on her store at the slip boatsheds, has four keys cut on Lantern Street, locks the letter behind the door with the panel, and lodges four bare notes with her solicitor to be posted after her funeral. Then she gets on, and is calmer for a few weeks, because it is out of her head. She does not expect it to be needed.

3. The three letters, sketched (Fable writes prose, blind)

The key letter (genuine, four identical copies, posted Day 12, read Day 14). If you've got this, I'm dead, and I'm sorry about the timing. Go to my store at the boatsheds by the slip. The padlock's new and these four keys are the only ones. Go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. Violet. Nothing else: no trust stated, no fear, no police, and nothing that says when the letter behind the door was written (the standing check from vo.1's failure).

The locker letter (genuine; Brad reads it at seven on Day 14; burned in her sink that afternoon with the drafts and the debt book). In her voice. It isn't any of you four, and I'd know. Someone with my key has been in my house, or I have started imagining things, and I cannot tell which, and both frighten me. The tin: the two a day she lies about, the stain through the paper, the loose lid, the bottle on the shelf above; I don't know whether I did that. The panel: the leak, the board, her own alphabet done better than she can do it, a mark instead of a name, two people in the trade who said yours; I don't know whether I made it, and if I didn't, somebody has been in my roof. Mum, on the shelf, facing the wrong way one morning. Then the instruction: each of you write down everything odd you've noticed this year, about each other and about me, however small, and read the four lists together at one table. Then the police, with something in your hands. Write legibly. Brad reads it and knows two things the room never will: pooled, the odd things name him (Ruby holds the marathon he called a wedding; Liam heard him price the van from the crane cab; Margo holds the debt and the calling-in), and the panel names a gilder. The letter must go.

The locker letter (forged; what the four read on the Monday night). Her paper, her pen, her hand, one long day at her bench with the debt book open beside him for her cursive. Her frame, kept word for word where he can: it isn't any of you four; someone with my key has been in my house, or I'm imagining it, which frightens me more. Her instruction, kept: write down everything odd this year, about each other and about me, and read it together at one table. The paragraph about the object: I have put Mum in here with this. Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting. Either way she is not staying on a shelf for whoever it is to stand and look at. Keep her where all four of you can see her until this is sorted. Then a starter list, "to show you what I mean", every item true: Liam has owned a third of the yard for eight years and lets the town think he's staff; Liam asked in March and again in July to take Mum out to the point on his boat, and I said no both times, and he didn't ask why; Brad told us a wedding in the spring and ran a marathon, I saw his time. His one addition in her voice: not the police; I've nothing they'd act on and I won't have them in your lives over a shelf and a loose lid; you four can do what they won't. Her close, kept: read this together, be careful, write legibly.

What he cut: the tin (a poisoning in her hand sends a nurse to the police through any ban), the panel (it names a gilder), and every word about money (Margo holds the list). What he added: the ban, and three true things

that lean one way. Nothing in the letter accuses anyone. Worked by four people for three weeks, it lands on Liam.

4. The seven rulings of 2026-09-08

#	Question	Ruling
1	The object beside the forgery	Her mother's ashes, in the crematorium scatter tube, four years unscattered on the back-bedroom shelf, where all four have seen it. Provisional ("for now"); the mother's mantel clock is on file as fallback. Played through nine stations in four-keys-locker-object-treatment-ashes-2026-09-08.md. The name board leaves the story; the empty hook and pale rectangle (R16) leave with it.
2	Margo's lock	A reading, not a proof. She holds three things: the debt book is gone (Day 8, told the sister, shrug; nobody else knew it existed); the letter that asks for everything odd about Violet's year never mentions the loudest thing in it, the calling-in of what she was owed, told to Margo on Day -120 with the list in Violet's hand naming Brad and the sum; and at a table listing everything odd, the one man who was called in says nothing about it, and he is the man defending Liam. Day 51 she opens her file to the Day -120 list, not the tax note. She cannot take a reading anywhere: a client's confidence, an omission is not evidence, and the man it points at is arguing for Liam. She stops arguing at meeting six; Brad notices; Day 60 runs as ruled. Only Brad and Margo know the debts were called in, so money never reaches the table unless Brad raises it.
3	The true letter	Burned, as canon (Day 14, her sink). The trophy Brad keeps is the panel on his wall, which the landlady's message already describes by the gap it leaves. Under vo.3 burning costs no voice: the four, and the player, read mostly her words in the forgery.
4	Chapter 7's turn	One fact: the letter asks for everything odd, and the two oddest things in her year, both known to the town and both in Ally's hands by chapter 6 (the panel carried round; the debts called in), are not in it. Left out, not got wrong. The panel names a gilder; the debts name a debtor; Liam is neither. Everything else in chapter 7 is consequence: four identical bare notes, so only the letter behind the door can be forged; the ashes beside it, so its author had been in her house; the letter kind to exactly one man. The boat owner's dawn sighting stays with Del, unaired.
5	Brad on Day 0	He goes up for the debt book, her book of everything, and reads it in her kitchen in the twenty minutes he waits. In her hand, dated: padlock changed, four keys cut, four envelopes with the solicitor, letter and the thing in the store. He learns on Day 0 that a letter exists and where, not what it says. He takes her mother that night because he already knows he will need something of hers beside whatever he writes. The forgery is a plan begun on Day 0, not an improvisation on Day 14.
6	The first minute	The danger is the gap between what she wrote and what happened to her: she said someone had been getting in, she said it wasn't any of them, she said she might be imagining it; she wasn't; she was dead; three weeks later the four she trusted with the only keys were sure it was one of them. Ruled lines untouched. Words to the three blind readers before ruling.
7	The panel and the four	Never shown to them, out of the teacher's pride, not fear and not shame (section 2). Answers "two signwriters and not the pupil" for chapters 6 and 9 without a new fact.

5. The room, week by week (replaces spine rows 14 to 60 in substance; days as v1.7)

Day 14, 21:00: torches, the padlock, a letter in her hand and her mother beside it. Margo: she's brought her mum. Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches. Liam carries the tube to Ruby's car, footwell not boot. Read that night at Ruby's table. The first response is relief, then the shame of relief: it isn't any of us. Weekly meetings agreed. The tube on Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall because that is how Liam set it down.

Meeting 1 (Day 19): the lists begin. Liam confirms the third of the yard the next day; the letter has told one truth and earned the rest.

Meeting 2 (Day 26): everything odd about Violet. The shelf. Who had been in the back bedroom this year. Liam, honestly: once, the window catch, spring. Margo underlines Spring.

Meeting 3 (Day 33): March and July. Why twice, when she'd said no. Liam: because it had been four years and I thought if somebody offered she wouldn't have to be the one who decided. Brad: that's Liam, he'd have thought that. Ruby: Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her. Nobody looks at the sideboard.

Meetings 4 and 5 (Days 40, 47): the lists worked against each other; Ruby drives; Brad defends Liam each time, reasonably, and loses. Margo, week five, alone at the sideboard for as long as it takes Ruby to say goodbye upstairs: a quarter turn of the label, and back, because it was not hers to touch. By Day 47 it has landed on Liam without one line of the letter having said it.

Day 51 to 53: Margo's sums (ruling 2). Day 54, meeting 6: she stops arguing with Brad. Brad notices. Day 60: Kestrel Head. From there as ruled: the three keep meeting, Ruby drives it; Day 77 Tessa's screenshot, word for word; Day 97 onward the withdrawals; Day 214; Day 215; the review, Days 222 to 262; the Gazette; Ally.

6. What changes, what does not

Changes. The premise device. The cold open's middle (ruling 6). Chapter 1 packages 4 to 6 (the key letter is bare; the second letter trusts). Chapter 2 packages 2, 3, 8 and 10 (the room, the tube, the reading's mechanism). Chapter 7 (ruling 4). Spine: A1 (Day 0 debt book; the ashes; no board), B1 rows 5a/5b (board rows retired) and a new row for the ashes and Liam's two requests, B3 rows 25 to 30 (the store letter's claims), C2 Brad (Day 0 knowledge), C5 Margo (ruling 2), D2/D3 (the decoy and the claims), R16 retired. The key letter ruled 2026-09-05 is void; the bare note replaces it. Terminology per v1.8. The sister gains one line: the ashes were Violet's to keep, and the sister, clearing the house months later, assumes Violet finally took her out to the point.

Does not change. The motive (the van money, called in for the fight with the sister). The panel (her alphabet, his mark) and the dosed tin as the thing that frightened her into the locker. Brad's PO box, dawn read and same-night swap (v1.7). His nine hundred days of preparation, the deckhand's papers, the vanish and the arrest under the deckhand's name on Day 333. Margo's six-week silence as the load-bearing lock, and her death. The survivors' fear of each other, the police look, the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions. The notch. The two survivors' refusal to name what stood beside the letter, which now needs no explaining: they kept her mother in a cupboard for three weeks and read her position like tea leaves.

7. The new facts, swept (who holds it; earliest competent action; where it lands)

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
Brad reads the debt book on Day 0 and knows of the store	Brad	Reach the store before Day 14	He cannot: the padlock is new and the only keys are with the solicitor; he waits for the post, which is what the PO box is for	Yes; tension, not a hole

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
The ashes are gone from the shelf	Sister (house keys from Day 5; clears at her own pace)	Ask the four; ask police	She is not close, assumes Violet took her mother out to the point, and is a little angry not to have been asked; if she does ask, the survivors say Violet asked them to keep her, and the sister waits. Ally hears "she was not on the shelf" around Day 290	Yes
Liam's two boat requests	Liam, Violet; Brad from the true letter	Liam says so at the table	He does, and it is what convicts him	Yes
The forged ban, "not the police"	The four	Ruby to Del, Day 15	A dead woman's letter saying someone had been in her house, or she imagined it: examination consistent, house locked front and back on Day 1, coroner's finding stands, nothing to act on; an intruder report on a closed accident sends nobody to the slip sheds, so the dawn sighting is not surfaced either way	Yes: the story survives Ruby going or not going; her not going rests on the letter's own "or I'm imagining it" and on nothing to show, not on obedience
Margo's reading	Margo	Say it in the room; take it to Del	Ruling 2: a client's confidence, an omission is not evidence, the man it points at defends Liam; Del: nothing	Yes, and the reason is stronger than v8.1's
The teacher's pride	Violet	None; it is a character reason, not an action	Brad hears from the café on Day -40 as ruled	Yes
"The ninth" (the date the letter gives for the shelf)	The forged letter	Anyone who was in her house between that date and Day -19	None of the four had been inside since before Day -19; the date is pinned after the last visitor and before the store letter	Yes, one date to fix
The four bare notes	The four	Any one of them goes to the store first	Only keys are posted together; the notes say together; Brad is the one who does not wait, and a boat owner sees him	As v1.7

8. The three tests any adversary will run first

- **Monday night.** Do the two letters contradict? No: both trust, both instruct. The questions that killed vo.1 (chronology) and vo.2 (purpose) do not arise. The room's first feeling is relief.
- **The middle.** Does a room told "it isn't any of you" end on Liam in three weeks? Only if the salt is true and the room is honest, and both are the case. The yard is confirmed on Day 20. Liam admits the window catch and the two requests because they are true. Brad defends him. Ruby never liked him. Nobody says it, and everybody has.
- **The end.** Is an omission a turn? The letter's brief was everything odd. The town supplies the two oddest things. The letter has neither. That is a contradiction between a document and the world, not an interpretation, and it is available to Ally only when she holds both the letter and the witnesses, which is chapter 7 and not before.

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. A third premise change has been proposed after two were rejected. Your job is to break it, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full, then

attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **Violet's engine.** She trusts all four, suspects none, and still buys a padlock, cuts four keys, writes a letter and lodges four notes with a solicitor rather than telling the people she would call first. Does "nothing to show them but a loose lid and a panel I may have made myself" carry that machinery? Attack the teacher's pride as the reason she never shows Brad the panel.
2. **The room on the Monday night and the three weeks after.** Four people read, in their dead friend's hand, that it is none of them and that someone with her key has been in her house. Find the question one of them asks that night that the delta has not answered. Then: does a room told "it isn't any of you" arrive at one of its own inside three weeks on three true facts and a turned shelf, without anyone noticing that they are doing the opposite of what she wrote?
3. **Margo.** Her turn is now a reading (the debt book gone, the letter silent about the debts, the largest debtor silent at the table), not a proof. Is a reading enough to make an accountant withdraw from the room, and later enough to die on? Find the day and the recipient of her earliest competent action, and say what happens.
4. **Chapter 7.** The turn is an omission: a letter that asks for everything odd contains neither of the two oddest things in her year, both known to the town. Is an omission a turn or an inference? Could Ruby or Liam have seen it on the Monday night? Could Ally have seen it before chapter 7?
5. **The first minute.** The hook is now "she said she might be imagining it; she wasn't; she was dead" and "three weeks later they were sure it was one of them". Is that a hook or a summary? Does the listener hold a danger inside sixty seconds?
6. **The new facts.** Take each in turn (Brad reading the debt book on Day 0; the ashes on the shelf and the sister who owns the house; Liam's two boat requests; the forged police ban; "the ninth") and find the earliest competent action any person in the story could take on it that ends the episode before its time.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.